

Education: Key policy trends in England

Education policy in England is currently moving in five clear directions: curriculum and assessment reform, a changed Ofsted regime, stronger careers education and work-readiness, greater focus on inclusion/SEND and children's wellbeing, and more place-based approaches in areas such as London. These trends sit across schools, colleges, and post-16 systems rather than in one single reform programme.

Curriculum and assessment are being rebalanced

A major current trend is the attempt to create a broader, more future-facing curriculum while still protecting core knowledge and standards. The Curriculum and Assessment Review Final Report and the government response point toward a system that keeps strong foundations in literacy, numeracy and subject knowledge, but also gives more weight to relevance, inclusion, progression, and preparation for life and work. The government has explicitly linked the review to helping young people gain the knowledge and skills needed “for life and work.”

Ofsted has shifted away from the old single-grade model

Another major policy trend is inspection reform. From late 2025, Ofsted moved away from the former headline overall effectiveness judgement for education providers and introduced report cards with more detailed evaluation areas. This reflects a broader policy direction toward fuller, more nuanced accountability rather than reducing a school or provider to one headline word. Ofsted's own materials present this as part of making inspection fairer, more detailed, and more useful to parents and professionals.

Careers education is becoming more embedded and more explicit

Careers education is now a much stronger policy priority than it was a decade ago. The Department for Education's statutory guidance published in May 2025 states that careers guidance covers activity delivered under the eight Gatsby Benchmarks, and from September 2025 secondary schools, colleges and independent training providers are expected to use the updated Gatsby Benchmarks to shape their careers programmes. That makes careers education less of an add-on and more of a core expectation within education quality and progression planning.

Gatsby Benchmarks: why they matter

The Gatsby Benchmarks are now one of the clearest markers of current practice in careers education in England. They provide the framework for what “good” careers guidance should look like, and they are embedded in statutory guidance rather than being just advisory best practice. In policy terms, this matters because it links schools and colleges more directly to employer engagement, labour market information, personal guidance, encounters with further and higher education, and workplace experience.

A particularly important current theme is the stronger push on work experience and work readiness. The government’s 2026 paper Every child achieving and thriving says it has adopted the updated Gatsby Benchmarks and states an ambition for every young person to have two weeks’ worth of work experience during secondary education. That shows how careers education is increasingly being tied to economic participation, transitions and employability

Ofsted: current significance

Ofsted remains central to education policy in England, but the direction of travel is changing. The current inspection framework still plays a major role in shaping school and provider behaviour, yet the reforms suggest a move away from crude labelling and toward more granular judgements. In practice, this means schools and colleges are operating in a policy environment where quality of education, inclusion, leadership, attendance, safeguarding and learner experience are all under sharper and more differentiated scrutiny.

There is also a wider children’s services trend here. Ofsted announced changes to inspections of local authority children’s services from April 2026, aligning inspection more closely with wider children’s social care reforms. That matters because education policy is increasingly overlapping with safeguarding, attendance, SEND and family support rather than being treated in isolation.

Every Child Matters: still influential, but no longer current policy
Every Child Matters (ECM) is not a current live policy programme in the way it was after 2003–04, but it remains highly influential as a legacy framework. The original Green Paper set out a vision centred on improving outcomes for children and young people across agencies, not just within schools. Its broad outcome logic helped shape later thinking on safeguarding, multi-agency working, inclusion, early help and child-centred services.

Today, ECM is best understood as a continuing influence rather than current branding. Its spirit can still be seen in the policy emphasis on wellbeing, early intervention, safeguarding, family support and joined-up services. The newer 2026 document Every child achieving and thriving echoes that broad child-centred approach, especially around early years, broad educational experience and support for children to thrive, even though it is not a revival of the original ECM framework.

SEND, inclusion and wellbeing

A major current trend is the increasing prominence of SEND reform and inclusion. The government opened a consultation in March 2026 on SEND reform: putting children and young people first, signalling continued change in how support is planned and delivered. Related government material says schools, nurseries and colleges will have a legal duty to create an Individual Support Plan for every child with SEND. Whether all details remain unchanged after consultation, the direction is clear: more structured support, earlier identification, and stronger accountability for inclusion.

This aligns with a broader trend across education policy: concern with attendance, belonging, behaviour, mental health, exclusion and safeguarding, not just attainment. The updated Working Together to Safeguard Children 2026 guidance reinforces multi-agency duties involving schools, colleges, early years settings, local authorities, health and police.

London-specific education trends

London has its own distinctive education policy environment because of the Greater London Authority's role in skills, careers and inclusion. One clear current London trend is the push to strengthen careers infrastructure through London Careers Hubs. The Mayor's programme is designed to work with eligible secondary and post-16 institutions, improve careers provision, and help institutions meet the eight Gatsby Benchmarks. The GLA frames this as part of ensuring that young Londoners can contribute to and benefit from the capital's prosperity.

A second London trend is the continued use of devolved skills policy to support participation and progression. The GLA Adult Skills Fund 2025–26 sets funding rules for provision for London residents, while other London skills programmes target adults facing barriers to learning and employment. This means London is not just following national education policy; it is also shaping its own local delivery model around inclusion, labour market need and progression.

A third London trend is the stronger focus on inclusion and keeping young people engaged in education. The Mayor's Inclusion Charter is a London-wide commitment shaped with young people, schools, parents, local authorities and education specialists, aimed at helping young people stay safe and thrive in school. That points to a distinctly London emphasis on inclusion, prevention and whole-system support.

Bottom line

In England, the current direction of travel is toward an education system that is still standards-driven, but increasingly shaped by broader curriculum goals, more detailed accountability, stronger careers guidance, more explicit SEND and inclusion reform, and closer links between education, wellbeing and employability. In London, those national trends are being reinforced by city-level action on careers hubs, adult skills, inclusion and opportunity for young people